

Week 6: Immigration, Multiculturalism, and Belonging

This week, we focus on immigration, multiculturalism, and belonging through Madeleine Thien's "Simple Recipes." Rather than treating immigration only as a public or political topic, this story brings the experience into the intimate space of the family — showing how migration, cultural memory, language, food, and conflict become part of everyday life.

Common Assumption #1

Immigration is primarily a public, political, or social event — a matter of arrival, policy, and integration.

Common Assumption #2

Multiculturalism means peaceful coexistence — visible in festivals, public policy, and official recognition.

The Reality

"Simple Recipes" shows that immigration and culture are also lived **privately** — inside families, kitchens, meals, and memories.

Immigration Beyond Arrival

When we think about immigration, we often imagine the moment of arrival: a person or family entering a new country and beginning a new life. However, "**Simple Recipes**" reminds us that **immigration continues long after arrival**. It continues in the home, in family habits, in language, in meals, in discipline, and in the emotional distance or closeness between generations.

Key Principle

Immigration is not only a change in location — it is also a **change in identity**. The domestic setting of the story matters because the home becomes the place where cultural memory is preserved, but also where conflict becomes visible.

Layers of Belonging

- **Family** — connection to parents, customs, and inherited memory
- **Canada** — the social and cultural environment children grow up within
- **Inherited culture** — traditions, language, and values from another world
- **Personal experience** — the child's own emotional and social life

These forms of belonging do not always fit together easily.

Multiculturalism and the Private Life of Culture

Canada is often described as a multicultural society, but stories like "Simple Recipes" remind us that multiculturalism is not only something we see in public celebrations, policies, or official language. It is also **lived privately, inside families**. Through this lens, the story makes the idea of multiculturalism more complex and more honest.

Public Multiculturalism

Festivals, policies, official languages, and public celebrations of cultural diversity.

Cultural Pressure

Traditions may provide comfort and continuity, but they may also create pressure when children experience the world differently from their parents.

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Private Multiculturalism

How people cook, speak, discipline children, remember the past, and express affection within the home.

Culture as Emotion

In "Simple Recipes," culture is part of the emotional structure of the family — not decoration or background.

A recipe may seem simple, but it can carry **memory, authority, care, and expectation** all at once.

Food as Memory and Inheritance

The title "Simple Recipes" immediately draws attention to food and cooking. In the story, the idea of a recipe becomes symbolic — it suggests the ways families pass down **knowledge, habits, and values** from one generation to another.



Food and Memory

A meal can preserve a link to the past — carrying the memory of another place, language, or family history. Cooking connects people to home and identity in ways that words sometimes cannot.



Food as Love

Preparing food for someone can be an act of care, even when that care is not expressed directly in words. The kitchen becomes a space where affection and cultural knowledge are transmitted together.



Food and Tension

What is passed down may include affection and cultural memory, but also fear, silence, discipline, or pain. Domestic routines can carry emotional histories that are not simple at all.

- i Thien uses the ordinary act of cooking to open a much deeper reflection on family life — showing that a "simple recipe" can contain a complicated inheritance.

The Family as a Cultural Space

In "Simple Recipes," the family is one of the main spaces where culture is learned. Children do not learn culture only through formal lessons — they learn it through **repeated gestures, household rules, family stories, tones of voice, expectations, and everyday routines.**

The Family as Living Archive

The family becomes a living archive of cultural memory. Parents and children may not experience culture in the same way. A parent may see certain values or practices as necessary for survival, respect, or continuity. A child may experience those same values as confusing, strict, or emotionally difficult.

A Critical Insight

Thien does not ask us to choose between love and conflict. Instead, the story shows how love and conflict can exist together in the same family:

1

Family as Source of Origin and Connection

2

Family as Site of Painful Memory and Struggle

Generational Tension, Love, and Ambivalence

A major theme in the story is generational tension. Parents may carry memories of migration, hardship, sacrifice, and cultural loss. Children may inherit those histories indirectly without fully understanding them — creating a gap between generations. The story refuses to simplify these relationships.



The Child's Perspective

Children observe more than they can explain — noticing a parent's habits, moods, tenderness, or silence without fully understanding the deeper history behind them.



Ambivalence

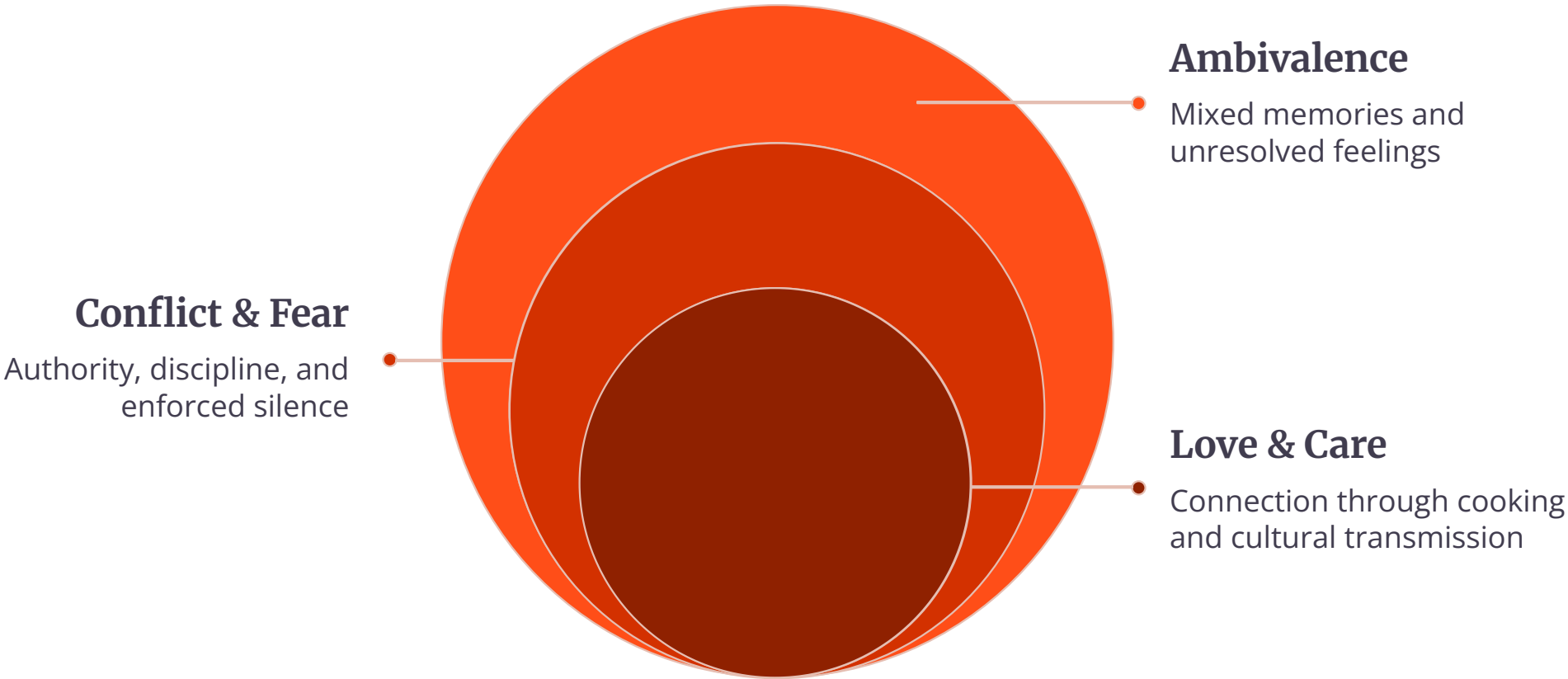
Having mixed feelings — love and hurt, attachment and distance, understanding and discomfort — all at the same time. The narrator's relationship to family memory is never resolved into one emotion.



Love and Authority

Care does not erase pain, and cultural explanation does not excuse suffering. The story holds tenderness and fear together without collapsing them into a single meaning.

Consider: A parent may show love by cooking, working, providing, teaching, or maintaining discipline. Yet the story asks us to hold this care alongside the experience of fear or pain — without reducing either to a simple symbol of cultural tradition.



Unlike straightforward narratives of immigrant success or cultural celebration, "Simple Recipes" relies on the reader to hold these contradictions — making reading a deeply participatory and emotionally complex act.

Belonging, Key Questions & Looking Ahead

Belonging in "Simple Recipes" is not presented as a simple feeling of comfort. The narrator belongs to a family, but that belonging is emotionally complicated. Thien shows that belonging can also mean being tied to histories that hurt — carrying memories that are both precious and painful.

Key Questions for This Week

- What role does food play? How does cooking connect to memory, care, family, and cultural inheritance?
- How are love and authority connected? How does the child's perspective shape how we experience the story?
- Does the narrator feel at home within the family? Is belonging shown as comforting, painful, or both?

Why the Short Story Form Matters

"Simple Recipes" shows the power of the short story form. Small domestic details carry significant weight — the preparation of food, family routines, and childhood memories point toward larger questions about immigration, culture, authority, and belonging. The story works through **compression**: it does not explain everything directly, but invites readers to notice how ordinary details become emotionally charged.

Reference (APA)

Thien, M. (2001). Simple recipes. In *Simple recipes*. McClelland & Stewart.
https://www.google.ca/books/edition/Simple_Recipes/